

plete rôle of Belshazzar may not have been recorded in such a document. As to the testimony of contract tablets ranging in date from the fourteenth to the seventeenth year of Nabonidus' reign, it must be remembered that those now published and deciphered do not comprise the total documentary output of Babylonia for the period mentioned. The likelihood that they represent a mere fraction of the cuneiform records of the time should be kept in mind. Definite inferences based upon their non-mention of Belshazzar would not be valid. All these considerations, however, do not alter the fact that it is necessary for us to deal with cuneiform silence concerning Belshazzar during the closing years of Nabonidus' reign. Berossus, whose record may go back to a Babylonian origin, gives no place to Belshazzar in his narrative.⁶²⁹ On the other hand, Herodotus and Xenophon, if their statements have been interpreted correctly, testify in favor of the presence of Belshazzar in Babylon when it fell, although he is not mentioned by name.⁶³⁰ A conclusion may now be stated. No document of Babylonian origin affirms that Belshazzar was present at the fall of Babylon. Nevertheless, no positive cuneiform evidence against his participation in the events of 539 B. C. has been found. Not a single intimation that he was deprived of power or that he was removed by death before the taking of Babylon by Gobryas is at hand. Balancing this with the apparent implications derived from Herodotus and Xenophon, we have some basis for the deduction that Belshazzar acted as co-regent until the end of the Neo-Babylonian empire. Future discoveries must determine how unequivocal this conclusion ought to be.

(b) *The opening words* of the fifth chapter of Daniel, viz. 'Belshazzar the king,' attract singular attention. It is an incontrovertible fact that there was a Babylonian prince by the name of Belshazzar; that he acted as co-regent in Babylonia during the absence of his father in Arabia is equally indisputable.⁶³¹ Emphasis should be placed upon the full meaning of these two assertions. The name Belshazzar (בלשאצר, var. בלאשאצר) is the Aramaic equivalent of Babylonian

⁶²⁹ See Josephus, *Contra Apionem* I, 20.

⁶³⁰ Herodotus I, 188; *Cyropaedia* VII, 5, 29f.

⁶³¹ See pp. 105-137.

*Bêl-šar-ušur*⁶³² = *Bêl-shar-u-tzur*. It is quite possible, however, that *Bêl-šar-ušur* may in practice have been pronounced something like *Bêl-shar-tzur*, i.e. with a suppression of the initial vowel of the final element (the imperative of the verb *našâru*) of the name. The approximation of *Bêl-shar-tzur* to Belshazzar is very apparent. Baruch's Balthasar⁶³³ and Josephus' Baltasar⁶³⁴ cannot be compared so convincingly with the Babylonian form of the name. Hence the fifth chapter of Daniel is linked with original cuneiform documents by the name Belshazzar. With reference to the second assertion, a cuneiform text states that Nabonidus empowered Belshazzar with 'the kingship' in the third year of his reign.⁶³⁵ All accessible cuneiform documents capable of throwing light upon the situation indicate that Belshazzar occupied this high position until the fourteenth year of Nabonidus' reign and the probability is that he functioned as co-regent until the end of the reign. There is no room for doubt that Belshazzar ruled in the kingdom next to Nabonidus. The writer of the fifth chapter of Daniel comports with cuneiform data in picturing the chief character of his narrative as having enjoyed kingly dignity.

(c) The fact that *Nebuchadrezzar* is referred to as the father of *Belshazzar* is one of the main features of the fifth chapter of Daniel.⁶³⁶ This should be interpreted with the following facts in mind. Babylonian texts and Greek data indicate that Nabonidus' ancestry and early life fitted him for marriage with a daughter of Nebuchadrezzar.⁶³⁷ Such connection with the reigning dynasty may be regarded as explaining Nabonidus' accession to the throne in the most satis-

⁶³² The meaning of the name is 'O Bêl, protect the king!' For the form בלסראצר see Lidzbarski, *Ephemeris für semitische Epigraphik*, III, p. 117, and Lidzbarski, *Altaramäische Urkunden aus Assur*, p. 15f. The former work refers to the occurrence of the name upon a stone statue, thought to have been found in Egypt; the latter refers to the occurrence of the name on two clay tablets bearing Aramaic records.

⁶³³ Baruch 1: 11, 12.

⁶³⁴ Josephus, *Antiq. Jud.* X, 11, 2f. Note the βαλτασάρ of LXX, Daniel 5.

⁶³⁵ *BHT* pp. 84, 88, col. II, line 20. See p. 106f of this monograph.

⁶³⁶ Daniel 5: 2, 11, 13, 18, 22. The form of the name used is *Nebuchadnezzar* and not *Nebuchadrezzar*. This is not a serious deviation from the cuneiform pronunciation. For Semitic interchange of *r* and *n* see Brockelmann, *Grundriss der vergleichenden Grammatik der semitischen Sprachen* I, pp. 224, 225, 226, 228, 229, 230, 231. It must be admitted, however, that if the form *Nebuchadrezzar* were present in the fifth chapter of Daniel it would represent the original cuneiform more accurately.

⁶³⁷ See pp. 16-33.

factory way.⁶³⁸ There are intimations in cuneiform inscriptions that Nabonidus considered himself in thorough accord with the house of Nebuchadrezzar.⁶³⁹ The queen who steps upon the stage in Daniel 5:10 is conversant with things that occurred in the court of Nebuchadrezzar. Her tone of address shows that she was not the wife of Belshazzar, for her solicitude appears to have been that of a mother. It has been shown that the consort of Nabonidus was the queen whom Herodotus calls Nitocris.⁶⁴⁰ The possibility and to some extent the probability that Nitocris was a daughter of Nebuchadrezzar has been dealt with at length in a previous chapter.⁶⁴¹ If the inferences which have been drawn are valid, Belshazzar was a grandson of Nebuchadrezzar. Should this prove to have been the relationship which existed between the two, one need not be surprised that the fifth chapter of Daniel calls Nebuchadrezzar the father instead of the grandfather of Belshazzar, as this is entirely in harmony with Semitic usage under such circumstances.⁶⁴² Of course it is impossible to know with exactness what was in the mind of the ancient author, but his reference to Nebuchadrezzar as the father of Belshazzar cannot be regarded as scientifically-established error.

(d) *That a festival could have taken place in Babylon* when it was being besieged is not unlikely. The walls of the city were regarded as impregnable by the Babylonians. Furthermore, the beleaguered inhabitants were supplied with a vast store of provisions according to Herodotus and Xenophon.⁶⁴³ There is little need to question the

⁶³⁸ See pp. 60ff.

⁶³⁹ See p. 73.

⁶⁴⁰ See pp. 42ff.

⁶⁴¹ See pp. 51ff.

⁶⁴² The Hebrew and Aramaic word for father is used in the sense of ancestor. See I Kings 15: 11; II Kings 14: 3; 18: 3; Isaiah 51: 2. In Genesis 28: 13 Abraham is called the father of Jacob. In II Samuel 9: 7 Saul is called the father of Mephibosheth, who was in reality the grandson of Saul. In Tobit 1: 15 Sennacherib is referred to as the son of Shalmaneser, omitting Sargon, the king who came between them. It was customary for Babylonian kings to refer to any one of their predecessors as their father. Thus Nebuchadrezzar called Narâm-Sin his *a-ba-a-am la-bé-ri*, 'ancient father.' See *NKI* p. 78, col. III, line 27. Note *šarrâni ab-bi-e-a*, 'the kings, my fathers,' *ibid.*, p. 74, col. II, line 46. Cf. *ibid.*, p. 110, col. II, line 77. In using the term 'father' for 'ancestor,' particularly of a royal predecessor, the fifth chapter of Daniel is in harmony not only with Hebrew and Aramaic, but also with Neo-Babylonian custom. See *Hwb* p. 3 for *abu*, 'Ahn,' 'Vorfahre.'

⁶⁴³ Herodotus I, 190; *Cyropaedia* VII, 5, 13.